


# *The Last Leaf*

## O. Henry · 1907

First published: The Trimmed Lamp, 1907

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

*Cover: Gustave Caillebotte, Paris Street; Rainy Day (1877). Public domain (Wikimedia Commons).*

# Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
4. Whole-book test and answer key
5. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

**Edition:** Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Trimmed_Lamp_(1907)/The_Last_Leaf (revision 13324710), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

**Grades:** Grades 6–10 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 1 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

## Essential questions

- What does The Last Leaf suggest about hope and the will to live?
- What does The Last Leaf suggest about art and sacrifice?
- What does The Last Leaf suggest about friendship?

## Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

## Standards and frameworks

- **Common Core:** RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4
  Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org
- **Indiana 2023:** 7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1
  Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

- **Dual Credit (Indiana College Core):** ICC-WC-1.1, ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.7
  Indiana College Core, Written Communication outcomes 1.1–1.7 (CHE guidance); ICC-WC-x IDs are ours
- **AP:** AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN
  AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)
- **Cambridge International:** CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5
  Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)
- **Liber et Libri program outcomes:** LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1
  Liber et Libri program outcome, not an official standard

**Primary codes:** RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, RL.7.2
**Assessments:** Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
**Differentiation:** Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
**Materials:** Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

## The 90-minute lesson

| # | Segment | Mode | Minutes | Clock |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Bell-ringer | You do | 8 | 0–8 |
| 2 | Vocabulary with etymology notes | I do | 10 | 8–18 |
| 3 | Background and context | I do | 10 | 18–28 |
| 4 | I do: modeled close reading | I do | 12 | 28–40 |
| 5 | We do: guided annotation | We do | 15 | 40–55 |
| 6 | You do: independent annotation | You do | 15 | 55–70 |
| 7 | Discussion | We do | 10 | 70–80 |
| 8 | Exit ticket / chapter quiz | You do | 7 | 80–87 |
| 9 | Closure | I do | 3 | 87–90 |
| | **Total** | | **90** | |

# Syllabus

| Week | Chapters | Lessons | Focus and activities | Assessment |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | The Last Leaf | 1 × 90 min (90 min) | *hope and the will to live*<br>• Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure<br>• Story quizzes in the app<br>• Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week) | Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt |

# Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

# Lesson 1: The Last Leaf

**Focus:** hope created by an act of sacrifice

**Content note (illness and death):** Sensitive content: Illness and death. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
**Student preview:** Heads-up: this story includes illness and death.
**Suggested language:** "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

In Greenwich Village, young artist Johnsy is dying of pneumonia and believes she will die when the last ivy leaf falls outside her window. Her friend Sue tells their neighbor, the old failed painter Behrman. Through a stormy night one leaf survives, and Johnsy regains her will to live. Then they learn Behrman died of pneumonia after painting the leaf on the wall in the storm: his masterpiece.

**Background:** Published in 1907. Pneumonia was a leading cause of death in crowded New York tenements before antibiotics.

**Significance:** It links art, hope and sacrifice through a single symbol.

*Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)*

**0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)**
Respond in writing to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
*Settle in and write for five minutes: Can a person's attitude affect whether they get well? What do you think? No wrong answers yet; we will test these ideas against the text. Two volunteers share, and I note key words on the board. Before we start, a content note: Heads-up: this story includes illness and death.*

**8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)**
Introduce 5 key words: pronounce, define from context, then the word's history.
*Today's words are swaggered, zephyrs, serrated, merciless, congenial. For each one we read the sentence, guess from context and then check the definition. Here is the first: "Then she swaggered into Johnsy's room with her drawing board, whistling ragtime." In this sentence it means: walked or behaved in a boastful, arrogant way. Word histories: For the other words, look up the word history (Etymonline or the OED) and record the language of origin and the root meaning in your etymology log.*

**18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)**
Present the historical and literary background.
*Here is what the first readers of The Last Leaf would have known. Published in 1907. Pneumonia was a leading cause of death in crowded New York tenements before antibiotics. Why does this story matter? It links art, hope and sacrifice through a single symbol. Write down one question you want answered.*

**28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)**
Teacher models a think-aloud on the anchor passage for symbolism.
*Watch me read this the way a careful reader does. The passage opens: "IN a little district west of Washington Square the streets have run crazy and broken themselves into small strips called "places."" I stop and ask: what is the author doing here, and how does it connect to hope created by an act of sacrifice? I circle "valuable", one of today's words, and ask why the author chose it over a plainer word. When I find symbolism, I underline it and write its effect in the margin, then I check my idea against the next sentence.*

**40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)**
Read the anchor passage aloud together; annotate for symbolism.
*Now we do it together. I read the first sentence and you track along. Mark every example of symbolism. Turn to a partner: what does the author want us to notice? I will collect three ideas and we choose the strongest using evidence.*

> *IN a little district west of Washington Square the streets have run crazy and broken themselves into small strips called "places." These "places" make strange angles and curves. One street crosses itself a time or two. An artist once discovered a valuable possibility in this street. Suppose a collector with a bill for paints, paper and canvas should, in traversing this route, suddenly meet himself coming back, without a cent having been paid on account!*

**55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)**
Students annotate a new passage independently in the reader, then begin the writing prompt at their assigned rigor level.
*Your turn. Annotate the next page in the app for Symbolism, Irony, Characterization: at least three marks with a margin note each. Then open your writing prompt; the app shows the level your teacher assigned (for a 9–10 class, the HS Sophomore prompt reads: Analyze how The Last Leaf develops the idea of hope created by an act of sacrifice. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of symbolism and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) I will circulate and conference.*

**70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)**
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions (focus set for the class level): wait time, think-pair-share on DOK 3/4, follow-up probes.
*Let's talk. We move from what happens to why it matters to whether it's right. After each question I wait before calling on anyone: think first. Our anchor question: How does this story connect to hope and the will to live? Every claim needs a page reference. Respond to the person before you by agreeing, extending or challenging with evidence, and end by writing one question of your own.*

**80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)**
Story quiz in the app, then a one-sentence exit ticket.
*Take the story quiz in the app. Then, in one sentence, tell me what this story suggests about hope created by an act of sacrifice, backed by one short quotation.*

**87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
*Today we saw how symbolism shapes hope created by an act of sacrifice. Tonight, read the next story and add two words to your etymology log.*

Total: 90 minutes.

### *Vocabulary with etymology notes*

| Word | Definition (in this sentence) | In context | Word history |
|---|---|---|---|
| **swaggered** (verb) | walked or behaved in a boastful, arrogant way | *Then she swaggered into Johnsy's room with her drawing board, whistling ragtime.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **zephyrs** (noun) | soft, gentle breezes | *A mite of a little woman with blood thinned by California zephyrs was hardly fair game for the red-fisted, short-breathed old duffer.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **serrated** (adjective) | having a jagged, saw-toothed edge | *Still dark green near its stem, but with its serrated edges tinted with the yellow of dissolution and decay, it hung bravely from a branch some twenty feet above the ground.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **merciless** (adjective) | having or showing no mercy | *When it was light enough Johnsy, the merciless, commanded that the shade be raised.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **congenial** (adjective) | pleasant and well suited | *They had met at the table d'hote of an Eighth street "Delmonico's," and found their tastes in art, chicory salad and bishop sleeves so congenial that the joint studio resulted.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **valuable** (adjective) | useful; worth having | *An artist once discovered a valuable possibility in this street.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **clinical** (adjective) | relating to the medical treatment of patients | *"She has one chance in—let us say, ten," he said;' as he shook down the mercury in his clinical thermometer.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **ravager** (noun) | one who destroys or lays waste | *Over on the east side this ravager strode boldly, smiting his victims by scores, but his feet trod slowly through the maze of the narrow and moss-grown "places."* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **solicitously** (adverb) | with anxious care for someone | *Sue looked solicitously out the window.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **chivalric** (adjective) | relating to the gallant, protective code of knights | *Pneumonia was not what you would call a chivalric old gentleman.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |

### *Discussion questions*

1. Can a person's attitude affect whether they get well? What do you think?
2. Where does symbolism appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with hope and the will to live?

### *Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)*

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

**Literal / recall**

1. What illness does Johnsy have? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Pneumonia
2. What does Johnsy believe will happen when the last leaf falls? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: She will die
3. Who is Behrman? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: An old painter who has never painted his masterpiece
4. Why does the last leaf never fall? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Behrman painted it on the wall
5. What happens to Behrman? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: He dies of pneumonia
6. Retell the three most important events of “The Last Leaf” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: In Greenwich Village, young artist Johnsy is dying of pneumonia and believes she will die when the last ivy leaf falls outside her window. Her friend Sue tells their neighbor, the old failed painter Behrman. Through a stormy night one leaf survives, and Johnsy regains her will to live. Then they learn Behrman died of pneumonia after painting the leaf on the wall in the storm: his masterpiece.
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “The Last Leaf”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “The Last Leaf” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “Then she swaggered into Johnsy’s room with her drawing board, whistling ragtime.” What does “swaggered” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: swaggered: walked or behaved in a boastful, arrogant way.
10. Reread: “A mite of a little woman with blood thinned by California zephyrs was hardly fair game for the red-fisted, short-breathed old duffer.” What does “zephyrs” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: zephyrs: soft, gentle breezes.

### Inferential / analytical

1. What does “The Last Leaf” suggest about hope created by an act of sacrifice? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: It links art, hope and sacrifice through a single symbol.
2. Find one example of symbolism in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas.
3. How does the irony in this story shape what we understand about hope created by an act of sacrifice? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.
4. In the passage that begins “IN a little district west of Washington Square the streets have run crazy and broken themselves into small strips called “places.””, why might Henry have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Last Leaf”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: In Greenwich Village, young artist Johnsy is dying of pneumonia and believes she will die when the last ivy leaf falls outside her window. Her friend Sue tells their neighbor, the old failed painter Behrman. Through a stormy night one leaf survives, and Johnsy regains her will to live. Then they…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Last Leaf” set up that the rest of The Last Leaf will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “Can a person's attitude affect whether they get well? What do you think?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does characterization appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with hope and the will to live? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
10. Background: Published in 1907. Pneumonia was a leading cause of death in crowded New York tenements before antibiotics. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

### Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “It links art, hope and sacrifice through a single symbol.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

3. Rewrite one moment of "The Last Leaf" from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about hope created by an act of sacrifice? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
4. Write three questions of your own about "The Last Leaf": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
5. Connect this story to art and sacrifice: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Henry need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
6. Is the symbolism in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
7. Compare how "The Last Leaf" treats hope created by an act of sacrifice with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Last Leaf see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve hope and the will to live? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about hope created by an act of sacrifice? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
10. What question would you most like to ask O. Henry about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

### *Annotation focus*

- **Symbolism:** look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Irony**: gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them

### *Chapter quiz*

1. What illness does Johnsy have?
   A. Cholera
   B. Smallpox
   C. Tuberculosis
   D. Pneumonia
2. What does Johnsy believe will happen when the last leaf falls?
   A. She will paint again
   B. She will die
   C. Sue will leave

D. Spring will come

3. Who is Behrman?
   A. The landlord
   B. Sue's father
   C. Johnsy's doctor
   D. An old painter who has never painted his masterpiece
4. Why does the last leaf never fall?
   A. The wind stopped
   B. It was glued
   C. It was plastic
   D. Behrman painted it on the wall
5. What happens to Behrman?
   A. He marries Sue
   B. He dies of pneumonia
   C. He becomes famous
   D. He moves away
6. In the line “Then she swaggered into Johnsy’s room with her drawing board, whistling ragtime.”, what does “swaggered” most nearly mean?
   A. having or showing no mercy
   B. walked or behaved in a boastful, arrogant way
   C. having a jagged, saw-toothed edge
   D. soft, gentle breezes
7. In the line “A mite of a little woman with blood thinned by California zephyrs was hardly fair game for the red-fisted, short-breathed old duffer.”, what does “zephyrs” most nearly mean?
   A. having a jagged, saw-toothed edge
   B. having or showing no mercy
   C. walked or behaved in a boastful, arrogant way
   D. soft, gentle breezes

**Answer key:** 1. D (Pneumonia); 2. B (She will die); 3. D (An old painter who has never painted his masterpiece); 4. D (Behrman painted it on the wall); 5. B (He dies of pneumonia); 6. B (walked or behaved in a boastful, arrogant way); 7. D (soft, gentle breezes)

### *Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)*

**Middle School** (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.4, W.7.1; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.12, 7.W.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Last Leaf,” how does Henry show hope created by an act of sacrifice? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the symbolism you noticed as one piece of evidence.

**HS Freshman** (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1): In The Last Leaf, how does Henry develop the idea of hope created by an act of sacrifice? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the symbolism in the story helps build that idea.

**HS Sophomore** (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how The Last Leaf develops the idea of hope created by an act of sacrifice. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of symbolism and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

**HS Junior** (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of The Last Leaf (where it begins, turns and ends) and its symbolism shape the reader's understanding of hope created by an act of sacrifice. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

**HS Senior** (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.4, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what The Last Leaf suggests about hope created by an act of sacrifice. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's symbolism and irony), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

**AP** (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: RL.11-12.4, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how O. Henry uses symbolism in The Last Leaf to complicate the reader's understanding of hope created by an act of sacrifice. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

**College Freshman** (1000 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate The Last Leaf within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of hope created by an act of sacrifice responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

**College Sophomore** (1250 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read The Last Leaf alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of hope created by an act of sacrifice follows or bends those conventions, using the symbolism as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

**College Junior** (1500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Last Leaf and its treatment of hope created by an act of sacrifice. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's symbolism and irony, and identify where the text resists it.

**College Senior** (2000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads The Last Leaf as evidence for a larger claim about hope created by an act of sacrifice in The Last Leaf. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

**Graduate / PhD** (2500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads The Last Leaf as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of hope created by an act of sacrifice. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Last Leaf.

### *SAT-style questions*

1. *Still dark green near its stem, but with its serrated edges tinted with the yellow of dissolution and decay, it hung bravely from a branch some twenty feet above the ground.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “serrated” most nearly mean?

   A. with anxious care for someone

   B. one who destroys or lays waste

   C. relating to the gallant, protective code of knights

   D. having a jagged, saw-toothed edge

2. *IN a little district west of Washington Square the streets have run crazy and broken themselves into small strips called “places.” These “places” make strange angles and curves. One street crosses itself a time or two. An artist once discovered a valuable possibility in this street. Suppose a collector with a bill for paints, paper and canvas should, in traversing this route, suddenly meet himself coming back, without a cent having been paid on account!*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Last Leaf”?

   A. A boy's romantic quest ending in disillusion

   B. Waking into a changed nation

   C. A story told to protect a livelihood

   D. Hope created by an act of sacrifice

**SAT key:** 1. D (having a jagged, saw-toothed edge); 2. D (Hope created by an act of sacrifice)

# Whole-book test

**The Last Leaf: whole-book test** · 90 minutes

## Part I: Multiple choice

1. What illness does Johnsy have?
   A. Cholera
   B. Smallpox
   C. Tuberculosis
   D. Pneumonia
2. What does Johnsy believe will happen when the last leaf falls?
   A. She will paint again
   B. She will die
   C. Sue will leave
   D. Spring will come
3. Who is Behrman?
   A. The landlord
   B. Sue's father
   C. Johnsy's doctor
   D. An old painter who has never painted his masterpiece
4. Why does the last leaf never fall?
   A. The wind stopped
   B. It was glued
   C. It was plastic
   D. Behrman painted it on the wall
5. What happens to Behrman?
   A. He marries Sue
   B. He dies of pneumonia
   C. He becomes famous
   D. He moves away
6. In the line “Then she swaggered into Johnsy’s room with her drawing board, whistling ragtime.”, what does “swaggered” most nearly mean?
   A. having or showing no mercy
   B. walked or behaved in a boastful, arrogant way
   C. having a jagged, saw-toothed edge
   D. soft, gentle breezes

7. In the line "A mite of a little woman with blood thinned by California zephyrs was hardly fair game for the red-fisted, short-breathed old duffer.", what does "zephyrs" most nearly mean?
   A. having a jagged, saw-toothed edge
   B. having or showing no mercy
   C. walked or behaved in a boastful, arrogant way
   D. soft, gentle breezes
8. As used in the story ("Then she swaggered into Johnsy's room with her drawing board, whistling ragtime."), what does "swaggered" mean?
   A. walked or behaved in a boastful, arrogant way
   B. pleasant and well suited
   C. one who destroys or lays waste
   D. soft, gentle breezes
9. As used in the story ("A mite of a little woman with blood thinned by California zephyrs was hardly fair game for the red-fisted, short-breathed old duffer."), what does "zephyrs" mean?
   A. useful; worth having
   B. soft, gentle breezes
   C. with anxious care for someone
   D. having a jagged, saw-toothed edge
10. As used in the story ("Still dark green near its stem, but with its serrated edges tinted with the yellow of dissolution and decay, it hung bravely from a branch s"), what does "serrated" mean?
    A. relating to the medical treatment of patients
    B. relating to the gallant, protective code of knights
    C. having a jagged, saw-toothed edge
    D. having or showing no mercy
11. As used in the story ("When it was light enough Johnsy, the merciless, commanded that the shade be raised."), what does "merciless" mean?
    A. one who destroys or lays waste
    B. walked or behaved in a boastful, arrogant way
    C. pleasant and well suited
    D. having or showing no mercy
12. As used in the story ("They had met at the table d'hote of an Eighth street "Delmonico's," and found their tastes in art, chicory salad and bishop sleeves so conge"), what does "congenial" mean?
    A. pleasant and well suited
    B. with anxious care for someone
    C. soft, gentle breezes
    D. useful; worth having

## Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how hope and the will to live develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
2. Explain how art and sacrifice develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how friendship develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

## Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (hope and the will to live, art and sacrifice, friendship) and argue how the ending reframes it.

## Answer key

**Answer key:** 1. D (Pneumonia); 2. B (She will die); 3. D (An old painter who has never painted his masterpiece); 4. D (Behrman painted it on the wall); 5. B (He dies of pneumonia); 6. B (walked or behaved in a boastful, arrogant way); 7. D (soft, gentle breezes); 8. A (walked or behaved in a boastful, arrogant way); 9. B (soft, gentle breezes); 10. C (having a jagged, saw-toothed edge); 11. D (having or showing no mercy); 12. A (pleasant and well suited)

# Essay assignments

## Essay: Hope and the will to live

**Middle School** (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Last Leaf teaches about hope and the will to live. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

**HS Freshman** (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how O. Henry develops hope and the will to live in The Last Leaf. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

**HS Sophomore** (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how O. Henry develops hope and the will to live across The Last Leaf. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

**HS Junior** (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Last Leaf (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of hope and the will to live. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

**HS Senior** (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of hope and the will to live in The Last Leaf. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

**AP** (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how O. Henry's choices in The Last Leaf (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of hope and the will to live, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

**College Freshman** (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Last Leaf's treatment of hope and the will to live in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

**College Sophomore** (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on hope and the will to live in The Last Leaf that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**College Junior** (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on hope and the will to live in The Last Leaf. Name your critical

method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**College Senior** (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about hope and the will to live in The Last Leaf, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**Graduate / PhD** (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on hope and the will to live in The Last Leaf, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**Rubric:** Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

## Essay: Art and sacrifice

**Middle School** (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Last Leaf teaches about art and sacrifice. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

**HS Freshman** (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how O. Henry develops art and sacrifice in The Last Leaf. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

**HS Sophomore** (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how O. Henry develops art and sacrifice across The Last Leaf. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

**HS Junior** (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Last Leaf (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of art and sacrifice. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

**HS Senior** (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of art and sacrifice in The Last Leaf. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

**AP** (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how O. Henry's choices in The Last Leaf (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of art and sacrifice, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

**College Freshman** (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Last Leaf's treatment of art and sacrifice in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

**College Sophomore** (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on art and sacrifice in The Last Leaf that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**College Junior** (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on art and sacrifice in The Last Leaf. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**College Senior** (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about art and sacrifice in The Last Leaf, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**Graduate / PhD** (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on art and sacrifice in The Last Leaf, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**Rubric:** Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

## Essay: Friendship

**Middle School** (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Last Leaf teaches about friendship. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

**HS Freshman** (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how O. Henry develops friendship in The Last Leaf. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

**HS Sophomore** (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how O. Henry develops friendship across The Last Leaf. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

**HS Junior** (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Last Leaf (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of friendship. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

**HS Senior** (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of friendship in The Last Leaf. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

**AP** (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how O. Henry's choices in The Last Leaf (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of friendship, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

**College Freshman** (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Last Leaf's treatment of friendship in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

**College Sophomore** (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on friendship in The Last Leaf that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**College Junior** (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on friendship in The Last Leaf. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**College Senior** (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about friendship in The Last Leaf, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**Graduate / PhD** (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on friendship in The Last Leaf, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**Rubric:** Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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